

ECCLESIASTES

ECCLESIASTES.

PREFACE.

This Book is called Ecclesiastes, or the preacher, (in Hebrew, Coheleth) because in it Solomon, as an excellent preacher, setteth forth the vanity of the things of this world, to withdraw the hearts and affections of men from such empty toys. Ch. --- Coheleth is a feminine noun, to indicate the elegance of the discourse. It is very difficult to discriminate the objections of free-thinkers from the real sentiments of the author. It is most generally supposed that Solomon wrote this after his repentance; but this is very uncertain. S. Jerom (in C. xii. 12.) informs us that the collectors of the sacred books had some scruple about admitting this; and Luther speaks of it with great disrespect: (Coll. conviv.) but the Church has always maintained its authority. See Conc. v.

Act. 4. Philast. 132. C. --- It refutes the false notions of worldlings, concerning felicity; and shews that it consists in the service of God and fruition. W.

ECCLESIASTES 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Jerusalem. This clearly designates Solomon. See v. 12. C. xii. 8.

Ver. 2. Vanities. Most vain and despicable, (C.) and frustrating the expectations of men. M. ---

S. Aug. reads *vanitantum*, and infers that this vanity of sublunary things is an effect of man's sin.

Yet he afterwards discovered that he had read incorrectly. Ret. i. 7.

Ver. 3. Labour. People fight for a mere point; for such is the earth compared with the universe.

Sen. q. Nat. Hoc est punctum, &c. Matt. xvi. 26.

Ver. 4. Ever. Its substance remains, though the form be changed. C. ---
At the end of time, it will be purified to continue for ever. W.

Ver. 5. Place daily. Its annual motion is then mentioned. C.

Ver. 6. Spirit. The sun, (S. Jer.) which is like the soul of the world, and which some have falsely asserted to be animated; or rather (C.) the wind is meant, as one rises in different parts of the world when another falls. Pliny ii. 27. M.

Ver. 7. Again. The sea furnishes vapours, &c. Homer (Il. Ph.) expresses himself in the same manner.

Ver. 8. Hearing. In all sciences there are many difficulties. If a man had arrived at perfect knowledge, his researches would cease.

Ver. 10. New. Such vicissitudes have occurred before, though we must not infer that the world is eternal; or that there have been many others before this, as Origen would suppose. Prin. iii. 5.

&c. C. --- Men's souls, which are created daily, are nevertheless of the same sort as Adam's was; and creatures proceed from others of the same species, which have been from the beginning. S.

Tho. p. 1. q. 73. W. --- Natural and moral things continue much the same. M.

Ver. 11. Things. Otherwise we should read of similar events to those which we behold. The same cause naturally produces the same effect.

Ver. 12. Israel. This was the case with none of Solomon's descendants. C.

Ver. 14. Vexation. Heb. also, "food of wind;" (Sym.) or "choice of the spirit."

Sept. People are eager to become learned, and yet find no satisfaction. H. ---

All natural things are insufficient to procure felicity. W.

O Curas hominum! O quantum est in rebus inane! Persius.

Ver. 15. Perverse. Habitual and obstinate sinners. C. --- Fools, who follow the broad road. H.

--- Heb. and Sept. "the defect cannot be numbered." We know not to what a height the soul of man might have risen, if he had continued faithful.

Ver. 16. Learned. Solomon was blessed both with a natural genius, which he improved by study, and also he had the gift of supernatural wisdom. Yet he declares that all is vanity and pain.

Ver. 17. Errors. Sept. "parables and science." But to discern the mistakes of men is a part of wisdom, (C.) and Grabe substitutes "wanderings," instead of

"parables," after Theodot. as Heb.

ealluth (H.) means "errors," (C.) or "follies." Mont.

Ver. 18. Labour. He is bound to do more for heaven, as he is convinced of his own defects, and of the strict judgments of God. Wisdom is not true happiness, but the means to obtain it. W. ---

The more a person knows, the more he is convinced of his own ignorance, (C.) and filled with grief, that wisdom should be so much concealed. S. Jer. ---

Those who are learned, feel indignant that their disciples should be so dull. M.

ECCLESIASTES 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. Delights. He speaks in the name of libertines, (S. Greg. Dial. iv. 4.) or after his conversion. C. --- The worldling might object that since wisdom affords not content, it is best to try pleasure. But this meets not with the approbation of the wise, as all terrestrial joy is short, and can yield no more than a passing consolation. W.

Ver. 2. Why. Heb. "What doth that?" Sept. "Why dost thou so?" Immoderate laughter is a sign of folly. Eccli. xxi. 23. C. --- "Even spiritual joy is a temptation." S. Jer.

Ver. 3. Wine, and to lead a temperate life. C. --- Prot. "to give myself unto wine, (yet acquainting mine heart with wisdom) and to lay hold on folly," &c. H. --- I wished to indulge myself in pleasure, yet so as not to lose the reputation of wisdom. C. v. 9. H.

Ver. 4. Works; palaces, towns, and particularly the temple. Many, like Solomon, will refrain from wine, and still yield to other excesses.

Ver. 5. Orchards. Heb. "paradises," in which fruit-trees were planted. C.

Ver. 7. Family of slaves, "born in my house," (Prot.) distinct from those whom I got for money.

H. --- There were generally procured from foreign nations, as the Hebrews obtained their liberty on the sabbatic year. --- Sheep. David had the like; but Solomon had also horses. 3 K. x. 21.

Ver. 8. Silver, which became, in consequence, of little value. --- Singing. At the court of Persia, people sung all night, and during the feasts. Athen. xii. and 14.

--- Cups and vessels; (Aq. and Sym.) or, "men and women to," &c. (Sept.) or, "a field and fields;" (C.) or, Prot. " as musical instruments,

and that of all sorts."

Heb. shidda beshiddoth. H.

Ver. 9. Wisdom, not that which was supernatural, and could not be found amid such delights. v.

3. Jam. iii. 17. I knew that all this was vanity. C.

Video meliora proboque,

Deteriora sequor. Ovid. H.

Ver. 10. Labour. Heb. "and this was my portion of all my labour." I perceived that I could not thus obtain content. C. --- "Thou (O God) hast made us for thyself, and our hearts are restless till they repose in thee." S. Aug. Conf. i. 1.

M. --- Aurelius makes the same confession as Solomon, respecting the insatiable nature of his own heart, and the emptiness of pleasure, &c.

Ver. 12. What. Heb. "For what man shall come after the king?" Sept. "after counsel?" Many other versions may be given of this obscure text. Solomon stopt at human wisdom, without consulting the divine; or he asks who shall have greater facility to acquire knowledge than himself, or equal his works? C.

--- Man's wisdom compared with God's is contemptible; though it be preferable to folly. M.

Ver. 14. Darkness and ignorance. He knows not whither he is going. Prov. iv.

19. and xvii. 24.

Wisdom is to be preferred before wealth, &c. C. --- Consideration directs a person to do good. ---

Alike. Thus worldlings speak, who reflect not on the life to come. W. --- In many respects all resemble one another, though their sentence be very different. M.

Ver. 15. Vanity. This inference was false, (v. 16.) or my labouring for wisdom was to no purpose.

C. --- Sept. "I then spoke more in my heart, (for the fool speaks out of his abundance) since this also is vanity." H.

Ver. 16. Unlearned. He answers, (Jans.) or rather continues the objections.

Geier. C.

Ver. 17. Life. Heb. "I hated life," as all is attended with anxiety. Rom. vii. 24.

Ver. 19. Solicitous. We naturally desire to have our plans perfected. Solomon had, perhaps, a presentiment of Roboam's misconduct. Eccli. xlvii. 27.

Ver. 20. Off, in a sort of despair; suggested by worldly wisdom. Religion alone can impart steady principles. C. --- Prot. "I went about, to cause my heart to despair of all the labour which I took under the sun;" in the transactions of the world. H.

Ver. 21. Wisdom. The writings of the wise are often perverted by perverse heretics. S. Jer. ---

Idle heirs dissipate the possessions, which had been accumulated with such industry. C. ---

Riches tend to encourage the profligacy of the heir. M.

Ver. 24. Drink, using with moderation the things which we have acquired, rather than to be solicitous for more, (W.) which may fall into the hands of an idle heir, who is appointed by God, v. 26. This may also be the plea of libertines, (C.) who would use freely what he has given. S.

Aug. con. Jul. iv. 3.

**Ver. 26. Pleased God, though he may not be his relation. Prov. xxvi. 16.
Job xiii.**

22. C.

ECCLESIASTES 3

CHAPTER III.

**Ver. 1. Heaven, in this world, where alone things change. S. Jer. ---
Nothing is here perpetual, but to be used in a proper manner. W. ---
The heart must not be attached to any thing created. C.**

**--- Pleasure had been condemned and approved. C. 2. He shews that all
must have its time. M.**

**Ver. 5. Stones, with a sling, or to render a field useless. 4 K. iii. 25. Is. v.
2. ---**

Embraces.

**Countenance was sometimes prescribed for married people. Lev. xx.
18. and 1**

Cor. vii. S. Jer.

S. Aug. Ench. 78. C. --- Hatred often succeeds love. v. 8. and 2 K. xiii. 14. H.

Ver. 9. Labour? What advantage does he derive from any of these things? C. i.

3. C.

Ver. 11. Consideration. Lit. "dispute." Heb. and Sept. "heart." H. --- Pagn. "He has implanted the desire of immortality in their hearts." --- End. If we could discover the properties of each thing, we should be in raptures; (C.) but as we cannot, this increases our vexation. M.

Ver. 12. Well; virtuously: or, perhaps, as literally, to enjoy himself. v. 13. C. ---

Thus thinks the man of pleasure. Is. xxii. 31. S. Jer.

Ver. 13. God. He gives peace and plenty; and still more, the grace to use these things, so as to obtain heaven. C.

Ver. 14. Feared. The order of the seasons, &c. teaches men to adore Providence. S. Jer. --- He has arranged every thing, how mutable soever. S.

Aug. Conf. i. 6.

Ver. 15. Past. He causes plants to spring forth afresh. Heb. Sept. &c. "But will God seek after the oppressed?" Here commences another objection. C.

Ver. 17. And then. Prot. "for there is a time there (v. 1.) for every purpose, and for every work."

At the day of judgment all will receive their due. H.

Ver. 18. Beasts. Another doubt; or suggestion of infidels. S. Greg. Dial. iv. 4.

Ver. 19. Man hath nothing more, &c. viz. as to the life of the body. Ch.

Ver. 21. Who knoweth, &c. viz. experimentally; since no one in this life can see a spirit. But as to the spirits of the beasts, which is merely animal, and becomes extinct by the death of the beast, who can tell the manner it acts so as to give life and motion, and by death to descend downward, that is, to be no more? Ch. --- Few are able to prove that the soul of man is immortal rather than that of beasts, since the bodies of both are subject to the like inconveniences.

The objection is answered C. xii. 7. C. --- The difficulty of answering is intimated by "Who?" &c. Ps. xiv. 1. M.

Ver. 22. After him. He knows not who shall be his heir, or how soon he may die.

None returns from the other world to inform him of what is there transacted.

Thus the libertine encourages himself. C.

ECCLESIASTES 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Any. God suffereth the innocent to be oppressed for a time, that they may merit a greater reward. Ps. lxxii.

Ver. 3. Born. It is better to have no existence than to be in eternal misery. Matt.

xxvi. 24. But the affliction of the just procureth glory for them. W. --- The pagan sages observed, that it was

"best for mortals not to be born; and if they were, to die very soon." Chalcid.

and Theognis. ---

But they considered only temporal inconveniences. Religion has in view the danger of sin, and the desire of eternal happiness. Rom. vii. 24.

Ver. 4. Industries, or Heb. "righteous actions." If one be poor, he is in distress; if rich, he is exposed to envy; so that all is vanity. C.

Ver. 5. Flesh, which he will not labour to sustain; (H.) or he repines at his own past misconduct, and at the affluence of others.

Ver. 6. Mind. These are the words of the slothful, (C.) or of truth. H. Prov. xvii. 1.

--- The indolent will not observe moderation in the application of this sentence.

M.

Ver. 8. Things? He acts as if he were to live for ever, or feared to be starved.

Ver. 9. Therefore is not in Heb. &c. The miser had better have some society. It is advantageous; though to refrain from its comforts, out of piety, is not blamed. The solitary must be "an angel or a devil." C. --- Society. Besides the advantages of friendship, this implies that a person must have Jesus Christ with him, that he may rise from sin and death by his assistance. S. Jer. W.

Ver. 10. Fall into sickness, poverty, or sin. The saints have withdrawn people from the dangers of the world into monasteries, where they may fight together against the devil.

Ver. 12. Cord. True charity increaseth in strength as it does in number, (S. Jer.

W.) though friendship may not admit of more than two persons. H. --- Some explain this triple cord of the blessed Trinity, or of the three monastic vows, the theological virtues, or the parts of penance, &c.

Ver. 13. Foolish. Great wisdom and prudence is required of kings; who, like others, are exposed to many vicissitudes.

Ver. 14. Prison. The exaltation of Joseph, Mardochai, and Daniel, was remarkable. C. --- Si fortuna volet, fies de Rhetore Consul. Juv. Sat. vii.

Ver. 15. Second heir. M. --- "They adore the rising (Papinius) more than the setting sun; (Plut.

Pomp.) and a person is no sooner on the throne than his successor begins to be courted: (v. 16.) so inconstant are mortals! C.

Ver. 16. In him. Many are perfectly unacquainted with the king, who finds so many admirers about his person, and even of these the greatest part begin to be presently disgusted, and wish for another change.

Ver. 17. Keep. Here many begin the fifth chap. as Solomon alters his style, and gives many important instructions. C. --- For. Heb. "rather than that fools should offer sacrifice, since they know not that they are doing wrong." Mont.

--- Do not imitate hypocrites, (H.) who have the appearance of sanctity, while they despise God's orders. Jer. vii. 2. C.

ECCLESIASTES 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 1. Few. As none can arrive at the perfect knowledge of God, they should be reserved in speaking of Him. W. --- De Deo etiam vera loqui periculosum.

Cic. de Nat. --- In prayer, (C.) we must not pretend to give him any information, like the heathens. Matt. vi. 7. H.

Ver. 2. Folly. Under anxiety a person is naturally disturbed with dreams, in which some true ideas may present themselves; in like manner, as a great talker will say some things respecting God, which may not be reprehensible, though the greatest part of his discourse will be nothing to the purpose. This is another abuse. All must speak of God and religion, though few are able to do it, with propriety! C.

Ver. 3. Pay it. Deut. xxiii. Vows must be fulfilled. W. --- God requires that we should keep the commandments; (Lu. x. 28.) and if we engage ourselves to perform some work of supererogation, he expects that we should be faithful.

To vow is of counsel; but to comply with it is of precept.

An abuse too common among the Jews is here condemned. C.

Ver. 5. Sin by making a vow, above thy strength, (Chal. Pineda) or by speaking what may excite the passions. Thaummat.; Bossuet --- Angel guardian assigned to each one, (W.) or the priest, who took cognizance of vows. C. --- Providence, or "foresight" in me to avoid the evil. Heb. and Sept. "it is an error," (H.) or sin of ignorance, for which certain victims were specified. Lev. v. 4.

The neglect of vows could not be thus expiated. C. --- Use no allurements to lust. M.

Ver. 6. Number. Those who observe dreams, are filled with apprehension. The Jews were very subject to this superstition. C. --- As dreams are vain, so are many words or excuses to evade a vow. Jun. Grot. --- Such pretences must not be made. S. Jer. M.

Ver. 7. These. God will bring the wicked to judgment, (C.) and shew for what design he left them in power. H.

Ver. 8. Him. An appeal may be made to the king or to God. Reges in ipsos imperium est Jovis.

Hor. iii. ode 1. --- Heb. "the king serves, (Mont.) or is served by the field." Prot.

H. --- All have a mutual dependence on each other, and thus the vanity of men and the order of Providence appear.

C.

Ver. 9. Money. Avarice is like a dropsy, (C.) or poison, infecting all the person.

Sallust. --- The miser is the slave, and not the possessor, of his riches, (S.

Chrys.) like Tantalus, who could not drink, though in the midst of waters. Hor. i.

Sat. 1. --- Nescis quo valeat nummus, quem præbeat usum.

Ver. 10. Them. He shews the vanity of the great.

Ver. 11. Sleep. Is not the health and content of the poor to be preferred?

Ver. 12. Owner. When they are taken away, they bring greater sorrow, (C.) and even when present, they fill the mind with anxiety. H.

Ver. 13. Affliction. Heb. "by an evil affair," or accident. C. --- Who. Heb. "and there is nothing in his hand." H. --- As temporal riches prove detrimental to their owners, so do false philosophy and heresy to those who follow them. S.

Jer. W.

Ver. 14. Labour. All must die in this manner. But it is most afflicting that he was formerly rich, and must leave his son indigent. C.

Ver. 16. Sorrow. The person whose riches have been taken away, had made a bad use of them, (C.) living like a miser. It would be more rational to indulge in the pleasures which they afford, though this is also vain. C. iii. 14.

Ver. 19. Delight, while he observes due moderation. His life passes away sweetly. C.

ECCLESIASTES 6

CHAPTER VI.

Ver. 2. Thereof. " Di tibi divitias dederunt artemque fruendi." Hor. i. Ep. 4. ---

The proper use of riches is rare. C. --- Misery. Riches do not make people happy. W.

Ver. 3. Than he, since the latter has injured no one, nor experienced any evil in the world, (C.) by his own fault; (M.) whereas the miser has both hurt himself and others, and has neglected to make himself friends of the mammon of iniquity.

Ver. 4. He. The infant, though some explain it of the miser. C.

Ver. 7. Mouth. We are always providing food. S. Jer. --- The rich are wholly bent on pleasure; or the poor cannot get a sufficiency.

Ver. 8. Life. The wise poor shall be blessed. Heb. "the poor knowing how to walk before the living," (H.) in society (C.) among the saints. H.

Ver. 9. Know. Enjoyment has the advantage over hope. Heb. "better is the sight of the eyes than the going of the soul," which denotes her desires. C. ---

Presumption. Heb. "vexation." H.

Ver. 10. He, &c. This is plainly spoken of Christ, whose name was given before he was born; (S. Jer. W.) or men resemble each other in all ages, (C. i. 9. C.) being proud, fragile, &c.

Ver. 11. Disputing. Are we better acquainted with nature than former ages?

This is another subject of confusion. C.

ECCLESIASTES 7

CHAPTER VII.

Ver. 1. Above him. We are intent on things which regard us not, while we neglect the important concerns of heaven. Hebrew may be joined with the preceding. C. --- Prot. (11.) "seeing there are many thing which increase vanity, what is man the better? 12.) for who knoweth?" &c. H.

Some strive to obtain riches or honours, which will prove fatal to them. C. ---

None can perfectly know the nature of things either present or future. W.

Ver. 2. Name. "It is necessary for the sake of others," (S. Aug. de B. Vid. xxii.) particularly for those who have to direct souls. S. Greg. in Ezec. C. --- In this second part is shewn that felicity is procured by a good life. W. --- Death.

Speaking of the just, for death is the beginning of sorrows to the wicked. C. ---

Some nations mourned on the birth-day of their children. Val. Max.

ii. 6. Eurip in Ctes.

Ver. 3. Come. While at birth-day feasts (Gen. xl. 20. Matt. xiv. 6.) people give themselves up to joy, and cherish the idea of living long. C.

Ver. 4. Anger. That is, correction, or just wrath and zeal against evil, (Ch.) is preferable to a misguided complaisance. Prov. xxvii. 6. C. --- Anger, when rightly used, helps us to correct our faults. W.

Ver. 5. Mourning. They submit willingly to correction, (S. Jer.) or think seriously on the dangers of sin and God's judgments.

Ver. 6. Wise man. Much prudence is requisite to correct with fruit, and to persuade the sinner that he is under a mistake. C.

Ver. 7. Laughter. It is loud and soon over. Eccli. xxi. 23. Lu. xxvi. 5. C.

Ver. 8. Oppression. Lit. "calumny." The most perfect can hardly bear it. Heb.

"oppression (or calumny of others. C.) will make the wise insane, and a present will ruin the heart." Mont. ---

Avarice blinds us. H. --- Deut. xvi. 19. "a corrupt judge examines ill the truth."

Ver. 9. Speech. Heb. "thing." The best projects often are seen to fail. ---

Beginning, as the auditor is on longer kept in suspense. ---
Presumptuous.

Rashness must not be confounded with courage. C. --- Hasty and immoderate anger is hurtful. W.

Ver. 10. Bosom, as in its proper place. The wise may feel its impressions, but he immediately makes resistance.

Ver. 11. Foolish. Men endeavour to excuse themselves by the manners of the age. But there have always been both good and evil. C. i. 10. C. -- - Corruption was prevalent in former times as well as now. M.

Ver. 12. With. Heb. also, "above, or much as riches." C. --- These are impediments in the hands of the reprobate, while they promote virtue in the good." S. Amb. Lu. viii. n. 85. --- The man who has only wisdom, cannot do as much good as those who are also rich. C. --- The moderate use of riches helps the servants of God, while they do not set their hearts upon them. W. --- The sun, to men on earth.

Ver. 13. Them. Money may procure necessities for the body; (H.) but wisdom gives a long and happy life. Prov. iv. 10. Bar. iii. 28. C.

Ver. 14. Despised. God never neglects first. Trid. Ses. vi. 11. --- He detests sin, and at last abandons the obstinate, though he never fails to offer sufficient graces. A person who is of an unhealthy constitution, or involved in sin, cannot be cured by man alone. Yet we must not cease to preach, &c. while we expect all from God, who gives the increase. 1 Cor. iii. 7.

Ver. 15. Complaint. Prosperity and adversity succeed each other, that we may be neither elated nor dejected too much. S. Bern. ep. xxxvi. --- If we enjoy the advantages of nature, we must be thankful; if we feel pain, we must cheerfully submit to God's will. H.

Ver. 16. Vanity, during this miserable life. --- Wickedness. This seemed more incongruous under the old law, when long life was promised to the just, (C. Ps.

lxxii. 3. Ex. xx. 12.) though it chiefly regarded heaven. H.

Ver. 17. Over just, viz. By an excessive rigour in censuring the ways of God in bearing with the wicked. Ch. --- Give not way to scruples, (S. Bern.) nor to self-conceit. Alcuin. --- Become. Heb.

"perish," being oppressed with majesty. Lorin. T. C.

Ver. 18. Overmuch. No sin can be tolerated. C. --- But as all offend in many things, (v. 21. H.) they are encouraged to rise again with diligence and sorrow.

Ver. 19. From him. Who is otherwise withdrawn, &c. Heb. "take hold of this, and not neglect that: for he who feareth God, will walk with all them." He will avoid all extremes both of virtue and vice. C. --- Prot. and Mont. "he shall come forth of them all," and advance towards heaven.

H.

Ver. 20. City. It has the advantage over more strength. C. ix. 16.

Ver. 21. Not. 1 Jo. i. 8. Crates said it was "impossible to find one who falls not."

Laert. vi. H.

--- We must not flatter ourselves with impeccability, v. 18. C. --- See Seneca.

Clem. i. 6.

Peccavimus omnes, &c. and de Ira. i. 28. M.

Ver. 23. Thy. We must be satisfied with a good conscience, as we cannot control the thoughts and words of all. S. Amb. Of. i. 1.

Ver. 24. Me. This is a proof of having made great progress in wisdom, since the half-learned are the most presumptuous. C.

Ver. 25. Much. Prot. "the which is far off, and exceeding deep, who can find it out?" H.

Ver. 26. Reason. Of all things. In this natural wisdom consists. Sept. "and number." He examined the pretensions of philosophy, which attempted thus to predict future events; but found that it was all deceit, like a harlot. Olympiod.

--- He explored the qualities of different things, as an arithmetician counts numbers. M.

Ver. 27. Her. He speaks by experience, (S. Jer.) as none perhaps ever fell more terribly victims of impure love. C. --- Though a plurality of wives was then permitted, Solomon did wrong in marrying strangers; and in suffering himself to be deluded by them, so as to erect temples to their respective idols. H. --- All the attractions of women are replete with danger, and can only be overcome by God's grace, and by flight. 1 Cor. iv. 8. Prov. vii. 22. and xxii. 14. C.

Ver. 29. Man. The superior part of the soul rarely thinks of good; but the sensual part always inclines to evil. W. --- Solomon found danger from all women, (S. Jer.) and there is none who may not prove fatal to those who are off their guard. C. --- Yet some are doubtless innocent, like the bless Virgin. H.

**Ver. 30. Right. He fell by his own free-will. S. Aug. de Civ. Dei. xiv. 11.
W. --- The great corruption of the world is not, therefore, to be
attributed to God. Eph. iv.**

**23. Our first parents were led by curiosity to examine whether the fruit
was good, &c. (S. Cyr. Cat. ii. Chal. Boss.) or mankind, in general,
make useless enquiries. --- And he. Heb. and Sept. "they," &c. C. --- Of
the word. That is, of this obscure and difficult matter (Ch). if this
sentence have any connection with the preceding. It is placed at the
head of the next chapter in Heb. C.**

ECCLESIASTES 8

CHAPTER VIII.

Ver. 1. Most. Sept. "he whose face is impudent, shall be hated." The truly wise and virtuous man is always polite and affable. C. --- As we may form a probable conjecture of a person's disposition from his countenance, so we may judge of man's virtue by their actions. They are right and meritorious when the intention is good, (W.) and the works themselves blameless.

Ver. 2. I. Prot. add, " counsel thee, to keep, &c. "Obey the king and God." H. 1

Pet. ii. 17. ---

**Solomon proposes his own example, or speaks in the name of the just. --
- God.**

The law of Moses, confirmed with an oath, or the engagement to be faithful to the king. 2 K. v. 3. 1 Par.

xxix. 24.

Ver. 3. Face. This courtiers observe, while many Christians neglect God. ---

Work. Defend not what has been said or done amiss.

Ver. 4. So? The eastern kings rule with absolute sway. Prov. xvi. 14.

Ver. 5. Answer. Heb. "judgment." He knows when to reprove even kings with effect; like Nathan, Elias, or S. Ambrose. 2 K. xii. 1. and 3 K. xviii. 17.

Ver. 6. Man. Solomon often reminds him of his misery. Sept. and Theod. "man is possessed of much knowledge," as they read dahth for rahth. C.

Ver. 7. Past. Prot. and Sept. "that shall be." H.

Ver. 8. Spirit from leaving the body, or the wind from blowing. There is no quarter given by death; so the wicked cannot escape vengeance.

Ver. 9. Hurt. Those who are despised in elevated situations, might have been happy in obscurity.

Ver. 10. Works. In life and death hypocrites are mixed with the unjust; and this excites indignation.

Ver. 11. Fear. Thus they abuse the patience of God, and grow worse, because he is good. His time will come. Apoc. xvi. 15 Eccli. v. 4. 2 Pet. iii. 10.

Ver. 12. Face. If God shew such clemency to the wicked, will he disregard his servants? Greek interpreters have read in a different meaning. C. --- Sept. "the sinner has done evil from that time, and for a long while," (T.) &c. See S. Jer. H.

Ver. 13. Let. Or, Heb. "it shall not," &c. Prot. H. --- Faith evinces that the wicked will be punished. --- But. Heb. "like a shadow." Sept. "under the shade," in prosperity.

Ver. 14. Vain, or afflicting. Hence some have denied Providence. Jer. xii. 1. C.

Ver. 15. No good for a man, &c. Some commentators think the wise man here speaks in the person of the libertine, representing the objections of these men against divine Providence, and the inferences they draw from thence, which he takes care afterwards to refute. But it may also be said, that his meaning is to commend the moderate use of the goods of this world, preferably to the cares and solitudes of worldlings, their attachment to vanity and curiosity, and presumptuously diving into the unsearchable ways of divine providence. Ch.

C. ii. 24. and iii.

12. Eccli. xv. C. --- Felicity is not attached to temporal prosperity, nor are the afflicted always miserable. W.

Ver. 16. Distraction of politicians, (Grot.) and of all human affairs.

Ver. 17. Reason. We know in general that God does all for his own glory, and for the welfare of his elect. But we cannot account for his treatment of mankind in particular cases. Rom. xi. 33.

S. Jer. C. --- Say. Sept. "speak what thing soever, that he may know he," &c. H.

ECCLESIASTES 9

CHAPTER IX.

Ver. 1. Of God. He seems to treat both alike, so that the just themselves cannot say whether their sufferings be a punishment or a trial. S. Jer. C. --- Knoweth not certainly, and in an ordinary manner. W. --- Hatred. Heb. and Sept. "yet love and hatred man knoweth not." H. --- Prosperity or adversity proves nothing. C.

--- Mortals cannot tell whether their afflictions tend to their greater improvement, like Job's, or they are in punishment of sin, like those of Pharao, and of the Egyptians. This they shall know after death. W. --- Yet the wicked know already that they are displeasing to God. Salmeron in 2 Cor. xii. "The just and...their works are in the hand of God, even love and hatred; men know not,"

&c. Dieu. Amama.

Ver. 2. But. Heb. joins this with the preceding not, " by all that is before them.

All things come alike to all, there is one event to," &c. Prot. H. --- The pagans distinguished real goods and evils from those which were only apparent, like prosperity and adversity, which are determined only by the good or bad use. S.

Jer. --- Thus religion looks upon virtue and vice in the former light; and riches, poverty, &c. in the latter. It may be difficult to decide, whether, under adversity, the just have supported themselves better by virtue, or the wicked by vanity.

God will manifest the truth.

C. --- Perjured. Heb. and Sept. "swearer, so he that fears an oath." H.

Ver. 3. Evil. People hence take occasion to indulge in vice, (C. viii. 14.) though the conduct of God be irreproachable. C. --- Shall. Heb. "they go to the dead."

H. --- Many think that these are the sentiments of the impious.

Ver. 4. There. Even those who have had the vanity to claim divine honours, never could persuade themselves that they would escape death. But the just forms a different conclusion from the wicked. He looks upon his life only as a preparation for the other, (Heb. xi. 13. Eph. ii. 19.) while libertines make haste to enjoy the fleeting pleasure. Is. xxii. 13. To the former death seems desirable, (C. iv. 2. and vi. 3.) to the latter it is a subject of consternation; and he prefers the vilest creature living, to the most noble when dead. C. --- Heb. "for whosoever is chosen (yebuchar.

Marg. yechubar, "is united") to all the living, has hope; for a," &c. H. - --

Moderns generally follow the marginal reading of the Masorets. C. --- "For who shall live for ever?" Sym. "Who partakes with all the living? There is hope."

Sept. H. --- During life alone the sinner may amend. C. ii. 3. The Gentiles are preferred before the Jews. W.

Ver. 5. Know nothing more, viz. As to the transactions of this world, in which they have now no part, unless it be revealed to them; neither have they any knowledge or power now of doing any thing to secure their eternal state, (if they have not taken care of it in their lifetime) nor can they now procure themselves any good, as the living always may do, by the grace of God. Ch.

Ver. 7. God. Be grateful to him, and make a good use of his benefits, (S. Jer.

exp. 2.) or these are the words of libertines. Boss. S. Jer. 1. explicat. C.

Ver. 8. White. As in times of joy, and among people of quality. C. x. 17. Prov.

xxxi. 23. ---

Head. Our Saviour reproaches the Pharisees for neglecting this. Lu. vii. 45.

Ver. 9. Wife. Some translate, "the woman," or harlot; as if the wicked still spoke.

Ver. 10. Earnestly. Live in delights, or perform many good works. C. ii. 5. Our Lord seems to allude to this passage. What thou dost, do quickly. Jo. xiii. 27.

Ver. 11. All. Thus it appears to the inattentive, and to the wicked. For Solomon frequently inculcates that Providence directs all wisely. Human industry is not always attended with success. Deut. xxix. 19. This is a fresh proof of the vanity of all things. C.

Ver. 12. With. Heb. adds, "evil." Net, (Mont.) or hook. H. --- Them. They may use precautions; but, without God's aid, they will not succeed. Ps. cxxvi. 1. C.

Ver. 14. And the siege, &c. Heb. has only "great bulwarks over or against it." H.

Ver. 15. Afterward, is not in Heb. The poor man was unnoticed before. C. ---

Vulg. insinuates that he met with no return of gratitude, which is but too common; (H.) and this shews the vanity of the world.

Ver. 16. Heard? Eccli. xiii. 28. Men are so unjust as to despise wisdom, if it be in a poor man.

The prudence of an individual has often saved cities, as was the case at Abela, and Bethulia; (2 K.

xx. 22. C.) and Syracuse was defended a long time by Archimedes against the whole Roman army. Plut. in Marcel.

Ver. 17. Fools. Though the wise often meet with contempt, it is only among fools, who form the majority. C. --- Vain declaimers in the Church shew their own folly, as well as that of their hearers. S. Jer.

Ver. 18. Things. A woman saved Abela; and Achan almost ruined Israel. Want of prudence in a general is often fatal. Virtues are connected, as well as vices.

C. --- For one transgression, many acts of virtue are lost. S. Jer.

ECCLESIASTES 10

CHAPTER X.

Ver. 1. Ointment. A fly cannot live in it. Pliny xi. 19. --- Hence the smallest faults must be avoided, (C.) and superfluous cares, (S. Greg.) as well as the conversation of the wicked, (Thaumat.) particularly of heretics. S. Aug. con.

Fulg. 14. --- Detractors may be compared to flies: they seek corruption, &c. A little leaven corrupteth the whole lump. 1 Cor. v. 6. C. --- The wicked infect their companions, and vice destroys all former virtues. W. --- Wisdom, or "a small...folly is more precious than wisdom," &c. of the world. 1 Cor. i. 25. and iii. 18. Dulce est desipere in loco. Hor. iv. ode 12. --- Heb. "folly spoils things more precious than wisdom." A small fault is often attended with the worst consequences, (C. ix. 18.) as David and Roboam experienced. 2 K. xxiv. and 3

K. xii. 14. C. --- Sept. "a little wisdom is to be honoured above the great glory of foolishness." Prot. "dead flies cause the ointment of the apothecary to send forth a stinking flavour; so doth a little folly him that is in reputation for wisdom and honour." H.

Ver. 2. Hand, to do well or ill. Deut. i. 39. Jon. iv. 11. Chal.

Ver. 3. Fools. People judge others by themselves. C. --- Thus Nero could not believe that any were chaste. Suet.

Ver. 4. Place. If the devil tempt or persuade thee to sin, repent and humble thyself; or if thou hast offended the great, shew submission.

Ver. 5. Prince, who seems to have been guilty of any indiscretion.

Ver. 6. Rich. Such were chosen magistrates. Ex. xviii. 21. Prov. xxviii. 16. and xxx. 21.

Ver. 8. Him. Those who disturb the state or the Church, shall be in danger.

Ver. 9. Stones. Landmarks or walls. Prov. xxii. 18. --- Them. God will punish his injustice, in meddling with another's property.

Ver. 10. Made blunt. After being repeatedly sharpened, (C.) it will be more difficult to cut with it, and will expose the person to hurt himself, v. 9. H. ---

Man, since original sin, is in a similar condition. --- Wisdom. The wise perform great things even with bad tools. Heb. "wisdom is the best directress." C.

Ver. 11. Silence. Prot. "without enchantment, and a babbler is no better." H. ---

But he compares the detractor to a serpent, (C.) as he infuses the poison into all who pay attention to him. S. Jer.

S. Bern.

Ver. 12. Grace. Pleasing and instructive. C.

Ver. 14. Tell him. How foolish, therefore, is it to speak about every thing!

Ver. 15. City. Being so stupid, that they know not, or will not take the pains to find what is most obvious. C. --- Thus the pagan philosophers knew all but what they ought to have known; (S.

Jer.) and many such wise worldlings never strive to discover the paths which lead to the city of eternal peace: like him who contemplated the stars, and fell into a ditch. C.

Ver. 16. When thy. Heb. lit. "whose," cujus, as v. 17. H. --- S. Jerom give two senses to this passage, the literal and the mystical, according to his usual custom. The dominion of young men and of luxurious judges is reproved, as well as innovations in matters of religion. Is. iii. 4. Those are blessed who have Christ for their head, descending from the patriarchs and saints, (over whom sin ruled not, and who of course were free) and from the blessed Virgin, who was "more free." They have the apostles for princes, who sought not the pleasures of this world, but will be rewarded, in due time, and eat without confusion. T. 7. W. --- Child. Minorities often prove dangerous to the state, while regents cannot agree. --- Morning, as children eat at all times. This may relate to the ruler who is a child in age, or in knowledge, though it seems rather to refer to his counsellors. Is. v. 11.

Ver. 17. Noble. Royal extraction, (Esthlon genesthai. Eurip. Hec.) and education, afford many advantages which others, who raise themselves to the throne, do not enjoy. Heb. "the son of those in white," (C.) or "of heroes."

Mont. --- Eurim, (H.) or Chorim seems to have give rise to the word Hero. The advantages of birth only make the defects of degenerate

children more observable. C. --- Heroum filii noxæ. "The sons of heroes are a nuisance," (H.) was an ancient proverb. --- Season. The time was not fixed; but it was deemed a mark of intemperance to eat before noon, when judges ought to have decided causes. Dan. xiii. 7. Acts ii. 15.

Ver. 18. Through. If we neglect our own, or other's soul, (H.) in the administration of Church, (S. Jer.) or state, all will go to ruin.

Ver. 19. Feast. As if they were born for this purpose, (Phil. iii. 19. C.) fruges consumere nati.

Hor. i. ep. 2. --- Money. ---

Scilicet uxorem cum dote fidemque et amicos,

Et genus, et formam regina pecunia donet. Horace, i. ep. 6.)

--- Heb. "money answers all purposes," (H.) to procure meat, drink, &c. C.

Ver. 20. Said. Pigeons are taught to carry letters in the east, and Solomon alludes to this custom, or he makes use of this hyperbole to shew, that kings will discover the most secret inclinations by means of spies. We must not speak ill even of those who are worthy of blame. v. 16. C.

ECCLESIASTES 11

CHAPTER XI.

Ver. 1. Waters. Sow thy seed where it may produce a good crop. C. ---
Be charitable to all. Lu.

vi. 30. Indiscrete faciendum bene. S. Jer. --- Assist those in distress, (C.)
even though they may be ungrateful, or unable to make a return. Lu.
xiv. 12. T. --- In this third part we are exhorted to serve God with
perseverance. Of all virtues, the works of mercy avail most. Matt. xxv.
W.

Ver. 2. Eight. To as many as thou art able, (C.) especially to those who
are of the household of faith, (Gal. vi. 10. H.) whether under the old or
the new Testament, signified by the numbers, seven and eight. W. S.
Jer. --- Mandatum accipis octo illis partem dare, fortasse
benedictionibus, (S. Amb. in Lu. vi. n.

49.) which intimates, that we must apply ourselves to the pursuit of all
virtues, as the number eight denotes perfection. C.

Ver. 3. If the tree fall, &c. The state of the soul is unchangeable, when
once she comes to heaven or hell: and the soul that departs this life in
the state of grace, shall never fall from grace; as on the other side, a
soul that dies out of the state of grace, shall never come to it. But this
does not exclude a place of temporal punishment for such souls as die
in the state of grace: yet not so as to be entirely pure; and therefore
they shall be saved, indeed, yet so as by fire.

1 Cor. iii. 13. 14. 15.

Ch. --- After death, none can merit. W. --- "He who shall not have
cultivated his field, (the soul) shall after this life experience the fire of
purgation, or eternal punishment." S. Aug. de Gen. con.

Man. iii. 20. H. --- The souls in purgatory have their names inscribed in
heaven, like the ancient saints, who were detained in the bosom of

Abraham. C. ---

They fall, therefore, to the south. Let people dispense their alms to all, as the clouds rain upon the just and unjust, (H.) upon the cultivated and the barren land, and let them do it before death. They know not how soon it may lay them low. C. --- By looking at the branches of a tree, we may conclude which way it will fall; so we may form a judgment of our future state, by reflecting on our present dispositions. "Our branches are our desires, by which we stretch ourselves to the south, if they be spiritual," &c. S.

Bern. ser. xlix. The liberal are not concerned where they bestow charity. People will gather up the fruit both on the north and south, and they who have given alms will find them (Abenezra; Mercer.) laid up in the heavenly tabernacles. H.

--- This agrees with the sequel. C.

Ver. 4. Reap. Those who are too circumspect in their alms-deeds, will often pass over such as stand in need, (S. Jer.) and people who reflect on the difficulties of a virtuous life, will never begin. S. Greg. iii. Past. xvi. and Mor.

xxvii. 5.

Ver. 5. Spirit. In a man, or of the wind. Why then wouldst thou judge of the merit of thy petitioner? or pretend to determine why God has made thee rich and him poor?

Ver. 6. Better. Be kind to all during life. Gal. vi. 10. C. --- Do good, both in youth and in old age, (W.) lest, if thou shouldst grow remiss, all would be lost. S. Jer.

Ver. 8. And the. Heb. "for they are many. What comes to pass is vanity." Mont.

--- Nothing can more effectually repress the love of this world. Eccli. vii. 40.

After Solomon has presented the objections of the wicked, he comes to this conclusion.

Ver. 9. Eyes. He speaks ironically, (C.) or exhorts to spiritual joy and moderation. S. Greg. Mor.

xxiv.

**Ver. 10. Anger. All turbulent passions, and evil or carnal pleasures. S.
Jer.**

ECCLESIASTES 12

CHAPTER XII.

Ver. 1. Not. Prevent old age, to procure a stock of virtues. H. --- Solomon refutes the former sentiments of the wicked, which he had perhaps once entertained. C.

Ver. 2. Before the sun, &c. That is, before old age: the effects of which upon all the senses and faculties are described in the following verses, under a variety of figures. Ch. --- All are exhorted to live well, before death come to deprive them of their senses and all helps: and to continue in expectation of judgment, the signs of which are given, as Matt. xxiv. W. S. Jer. --- Rain. One misery succeeds another, the understanding is darkened, and the senses become dull. C. --- The Jews explain v. 2. 7. of the future distress of their nation under captivity. S. Jer. H.

Ver. 3. House. The sides, (S. Jer.) or rather the arms. C. --- Some understand prelates, or angels.

Thaumat. --- And the powers that are in heaven shall be moved. Mar. xiii. 25. H.

--- Men. The arms, (Chal.) or thighs, (Smith) or those who were formerly the most robust. --- Number. The rest have been lost, and what remain are of little service for chewing meat. C. --- Holes. Spectacles, (Geier) as if they had been already in use. C. --- Heb. "windows." H.

Ver. 4. Doors. The lips, (C.) feet, (Chal.) nostrils, (Vat.) or the trachea and pulmonary arteries.

--- Bird. The cock-crowing; or at the least sound their slumbers are broken. ---

Deaf. Heb. "be low." The ears cannot enjoy music, nor can the voice of the old people please. 2 K. xix. 25.

Ver. 5. Way. They shall walk bent down, and afraid of rough ground. ---

Flourish. Their head shall become white, like the almond-flower. Jer. i. 11. ---

**Fat. Sept. "heavy." --- Destroyed. The hair shall fall off. C. ---
Concupiscence shall be extinct. Vat. T. --- Eternity. The body being
consigned to the grave, and the soul to the region of spirits, to have no
farther concern with the transactions of the world. H. Job vii. 9. ---
Street. This custom is often mentioned. Herod. ii.**

**85. Lu. vii. 32. --- The women dance, having one (C.) or two old people
disfigured in the midst of them, to recount the actions of the deceased.
Brun.**

**Ver. 6. Cord. The nerves. --- Fillet. Veins, or the spermatic vessels, (C.)
and the soul. S. Jer. ---**

Cistern. When the bladder, &c. become disordered. Num. xxiv. 7. C.

**Ver. 7. It. Man is composed of two distinct parts; the destination of
which we ought never to forget. Thus the objection of infidels (c. iii. 19.)
is refuted. Plato and some of the ancients had the same idea of the
soul's spiritual nature; though some took it to be an aerial body. C.**

**Ver. 8. Ecclesiastes. "The preacher." W. --- He returns to his first
proposition, and having pushed the objection of free-thinkers as far as
possible, shews us what we ought to believe and practise. He establishes
the distinction of soul and body, the advantage of instruction, (v. 11.)
without meddling with things too high, (v. 12.) the obligation of fearing
God, (v. 13.) and future retribution. v.**

14. This is the sum of all sound morality. C.

**Ver. 10. Profitable. Heb. "pleasing." Utile dulci. H. --- Perhaps he
condemns his attempt to know all things. c. i. 13. C.**

Ver. 11. In. The ground, (H.) to keep a tent in its proper place. He seemed before to have placed the wise on the same level with fools. C. vi. 8. 11. and vii.

1. C. --- Shepherd. God, or Solomon.

The Jews explain it of Moses, and his successors, who taught the people.

Ver. 12. Not. I have had experience of all. --- End. They can teach nothing farther. C. ---

Tenet insanabile multos

Scribendi cacoethes. Juv. Sat. vii.

--- Impious productions abound, while those which promote piety are too scarce. When the same truths are enforced, as those which the Scriptures contain, we cannot be accused of writing many books. Orig. Philoc. v. S. Jer.

--- Flesh. It ruins the health.

Ver. 13. All man. The whole business and duty of man. Ch. --- This is the sum of all profitable doctrine. W. --- He who does not fear God, deserves not the title of man. He is nothing but vanity. C.

Ver. 14. Error. Or hidden and secret things. Ch. --- Heb. "with every secret thing," (Prot. H.)

"every inadvertency." Sept. Sym. C.